

NATURE WALKS

by

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EXT. STREAM - MORNING

A leaf floats downstream before settling at the muddy shore.

We hear the warm voice of a young adult named AVON (20s, gender non-specific).

AVON (V.O.)
Hear that?

MATCH CUT TO:

EXT. NATURE TRAIL - AFTERNOON

A SOAKED LEAF sits on the ground.

Without seeing their face, Avon picks up the leaf. They are , wearing a fishing shirt and convertible shorts, with their feet protected by hiking sandals. A brimmed hat sits low on their head.

Another person named Laine (20s, gender non-specific and Southern) faces opposite of them. We also do not see much of Laine yet. They wear a denim jacket over an earthy shirt, with work boots beneath cuffed jeans.

LAINES' POV: Avon obscures their face by holding up the leaf to Laine.

LAINES
Done seen it, now.

Avon pushes the leaf down, revealing Laine's eyes, but still hiding Laine's mouth and nose. Avon shakes their wet hand. Droplets fly.

LAINES (CONT'D)
Feels...

AVON
The feels.

Avon holds Laine's hand.

LAINES (O.S.)
Reckon, I smell...

Avon pushes the leaf away, revealing Laine's face.

AVON
Well least your lips still taste go-

Avon is about to kiss Laine but Laine turns away. We still never see Avon's face.

We follow Laine's physique, as it hides Avon's.

AVON (CONT'D)

Life's good not to walk it alone.

LAINE

With you and that phone of yours,
we ain't never been alone...

AVON

Love spreading our love, you know?

LAINE

Sometimes I wish the whole wide
world wasn't watching us all the
time.

Avon turns away even more, offended.

AVON

Glad you're taking a detour to
visit my world for once.

LAINE

It's been a long long longggg time.

AVON

Graduate yetttt?

LAINE

Naw. When I do, what's the point
anyhow?

AVON

Umm... Money?

LAINE

Doesn't matter when you're dead.

AVON

I ain't so sure about that...

Laine releases the leaf. The leaf slowly floats onto a muddy puddle with a slow-mo SPLASH.

LAINE (O.S.)

Ain't here to hear that kind of
talk-

A phone RINGS once with Laine's intrusive ringtone.

AVON

You gonna answer that?

Laine pulls their pockets out, showing a marker but no phone.

They hold out a photo of them together in a studio. Behind them is a banner: RIVER TALKS. Laine's finger blocks Avon's face.

LAINE

There's your answer, now. You happy with it?

AVON

Didn't answer my question. Who called?

LAINE

My life. It wants me back.

AVON

Everyone wants *our* life back. Hear me out.

LAINE

No...

AVON

That's the problem-

LAINE

Please no-

AVON

Next season of *River Talks*-

LAINE

There won't be a next season!

Avon looks away, still never revealing much of their face. They step behind a dense cluster of leaves, disappearing without a sound.

Laine turns sharply, tears welling, to face Avon's makeshift memorial underneath an old tree by a river.

LAINE (CONT'D)

Not when you're...

Laine spins back around, but Avon is gone.

LAINE (CONT'D)

Crazy- Laine. Knew I shouldn't have come here. You're not- Not ready.

Laine drops the photo by the memorial.

LAINE (O.S.) (CONT'D)
It's over...

A gust of wind suddenly RUSHES through the trees. A single leaf is carried by the wind and lands precisely on the photo, covering Avon's face before we see it.

MATCH CUT TO:

EXT. NATURE TRAIL - MOMENTS LATER

A MUDDY PUDDLE lies dormant on the ground.

Laine walks past it, their pace quick and determined. They pass the leaf they dropped earlier.

The phone RINGS once, piercing the silence of the woods.

Laine STOPS, then turns around.

LAINE
It's over!

Laine spins back around and continues walking away, faster this time.

The single leaf SKITTERS to life, rolling behind Laine. The phone RINGS again and again as the leaf moves.

LAINE (CONT'D)
It's not over!

Laine turns, charging after the leaf. It flutters off and away, its ringtone a mocking sound.

Laine TRIPS hard on a gnarled tree root and goes unconscious.

INT. LAINE'S BEDROOM - EVENING - FLASHBACK

RAIN LASHES against the window.

Laine lies on their bed with their phone in hand. On it are news alert of flash floods. The phone RINGS: AVON <3. Laine stares at it, paralyzed. They listen to their voicemail.

AVON (V.O.)
Avon to Laine... Just one last time
at the river. Not the podcast
finale. For our finale as a pod.
Please don't leave...

Laine places the phone on their desk. The desk is full of pro-privacy books and artwork objecting to technology.

JUMP CUT TO:

INT. LAINE'S BEDROOM - NIGHT - MOMENTS LATER

The phone on the desk reveals several missed calls. A message from Avon reads: "Thanks for being..." It is now an alarm.

PRE-LAP: The beeping of a phone alarm.

MATCH CUT TO:

EXT. NATURE NOWHERE - NIGHT

The sound of the alarm is the only thing in the darkness. A single leaf lies dormant on the ground. We see Laine lie asleep nearby.

Laine groans awake and taps the leaf, as if it were the phone screen, to shut off the alarm.

Laine looks around at the unfamiliar, dense woods.

LAINE

You wouldn't happen to be a map
too?

Another leaf tumbles from above and lands by their feet.

LAINE (CONT'D)

I won't fall for this.

Laine goes between two trees to exit. Another leaf blocks their way. Laine tries to go around.

Laine tries to go around, but it latches onto their leg.

Laine falls, with a sharp breath in their leg. The surrounding woods seem to press in closer.

We hear the recorded audio of Avon and Laine's podcast: RIVER TALKS.

AVON & LAINE (V.O.)

Nature walks so rivers could talk.
It's the River Talks podcast!

AVON (V.O.)

It's Avon!

Real-life Laine, miserable and in pain on the ground, occasionally repeats the podcast audio.

LAINÉ (V.O.) LAINÉ
I'm Laine! (Miserably)
And Laine...

AVON (V.O.)
On our first episode, we wanted to-

LAINÉ (V.O.)
Take a hike!

AVON (V.O.)
But sike! Didn't happen cause...

LAINÉ (V.O.) LAINÉ
I sprained my leg. I didn't wanna...

LAINÉ (V.O.)
No nature hike...

AVON (V.O.)
But a nature walk will do!

LAINÉ (V.O.)
Nature walks so...

AVON (V.O.)
River Talks now streaming on...
Laine, what are we streaming on?

LAINÉ (V.O.)
Nothing yet.

AVON (V.O.)
Nothing yet!

LAINÉ
Now streaming on Leafify...

Laine pushes themselves up, wincing.

LAINÉ (V.O.)
Avon, we need to decide on a
streaming service.

AVON (V.O.)
Let's get in the river together.

LAINÉ
Oh... That's been your issue this
whole time. Wait- Why you pausing?!

Another leaf lands by their side. This one is more ominous.

AVON (V.O.)

Laine... Speak into the mic. The recording would sound better.

Laine now sees this new leaf as a threat. They warily pick it up and hold it like a microphone.

LAINE

Bless your heart. You're just copyin' SubwayTakes and you know it good and well.

AVON (V.O.)

So this will absolutely take off!

The forest falls into a deafening silence

AVON (V.O.)

Hello, Laine. Now, where were we?

LAINE

No, where am I?!

AVON (V.O.)

To put it simply, for how much nature walks, they need lots of food and energy. So nature eats too-

LAINE

Did Mother Nature just up and eat me raw?!

Avon snaps their fingers. SNAP. SNAP.

AVON (V.O.)

SHEEEE ATEEEEEEE! But she ain't content.

LAINE

I don't give a rat's as-

The leaf in Laine's hand TWISTS and SLAPS Laine across the face.

AVON (V.O.)

The FCC doesn't allow curses-

LAINE

River Talks is not broadcasted-

The leaf SLAPS Laine again, harder this time.

LAINE (CONT'D)

Can - the - FCC ban whatever curses
you brought upon these leaves?!

AVON (V.O.)

The leaves are not the curses. It's
your actions of leaving that cursed
me.

LAINE

Lord have mercy, I can't hardly
believe you right now.

AVON (V.O.)

You stopped believing in us!

LAINE

The podcast is wishy-washy-

AVON (V.O.)

Not the podcast- We were whatever
those uncs say: peas in a pod.

LAINE

Piss off. Go on now. As a pea, we
was meant for a closed pod, plain
and simple. But you just had to air
it out for the whole wide world to
see with that phone and all that
recording and-

AVON (V.O.)

Believe it or not, you're not
leaving until you believe my
leaves.

LAINE

I'm leaving that word behind.

AVON (V.O.)

You're leaving the world?

LAINE

No, the word "leave"-

Laine tries to force a path between the trees. A leaf THUDS
onto the ground directly in their path, stopping them cold.

LAINE (CONT'D)

Oh my God.

AVON (V.O.)
I'd love to introduce you to them.
Did you know they have six fingers,
so no single middle finger...

Laine holds their middle fingers at the leaf. Their skin is noticeably a mosaic of dried leaves.

AVON (V.O.)
My favorite finger of yours.

As Laine shifts their weight, it sounds like crinkling paper.

LAINE
I... can't... hardly... stay...
put... here.

AVON (V.O.)
You always wanted to be still. To
just... be.

LAINE
Not like this here! I'm cold.

AVON (V.O.)
That's just the silence setting in.
If you don't talk, if you don't
walk, you'll just be another leaf
on the ground.

LAINE
You're twisted!

AVON (V.O.)
Twisted leaves are just healthy
leaves with lots of stress. Like
you right now.

LAINE
I might could burn you all up once
I learn how to make me a fire!

AVON (V.O.)
Stop running away. Walk it out.

Laine tries to run. Every time their foot hits the dirt, a dry CRUNCH echoes like a gunshot.

AVON (V.O.)
And here we see an avoidant in
their natural habitat. Notice the
frantic pace. The way they refuse
to appreciate the scenery.

LAINE

Hush up now! Just shut up!

Laine tries to sprint, but their legs feel like damp wood.

AVON (V.O.)

I'll give you a leg up...

LAINE

Is this here what you was fixin' to happen? To end up like you done?

AVON (V.O.)

To go stream with me!

Laine looks around, trying to think logically. They spot a distinct tree further away.

LAINE

Alright now... Got myself a landmark. I reckon I ain't stupid.

Laine points to the tree and begins walking deliberately, eyes fixed on their goal. They walk for minutes. The determined look on their face slowly melts into confusion, then dawning horror.

Laine stops. They look around, recognizing the spot where they fell moments ago. The kick-out leaf is still there. They've walked in a complete circle.

LAINE (CONT'D)

Naw. No, no, no...

They spin around to look at the path they just came from.

AVON (V.O.)

You can't outwalk your own shadow, Laine. Or your past, for that matter.

Laine drops to their knees in despair.

AVON (V.O.)

I need you to listen. You're so busy letting me get under your skin.

Laine looks at their muddy hands in disgust.

LAINE

Fine. I'll go under.

They pick up a stone and furiously dig into the Earth.

Laine struggles as their hands sink deeper into the mud. As their fingers graze the stone, a SNAP echoes. Laine's pinky finger has broken off like a dead twig, fluttering to the ground without a drop of blood.

Laine screams, but it comes out like the rustle of branches.

AVON (V.O.)

And that's why we never skip the stretches!

LAINE

Give it on back! Give me my own hand back, dangit!

AVON (V.O.)

I wish you gave me a hand last we talked...

As quickly as Laine dug it, the hole spontaneously fills itself in with more leaves.

AVON (V.O.)

Trying to bury the past again?
Doesn't work in the real world,
definitely doesn't work here.

We see the rock in Laine's hand, covered in mud.

MATCH CUT TO:

INT. LAINE'S BEDROOM - NIGHT - MOMENTS LATER

In Laine's hand, the phone is illuminated by a news alert: "Drowning Reported in Local Stream." The date matches the previous flashback.

MATCH CUT TO:

EXT. NATURE NOWHERE - CONTINUOUS

We see the rock in Laine's hand again. Laine flings the rock away in a fit of pure rage.

Laine, covered in mud and feeling their body change, reaches a breaking point. They look up at the dark sky and scream.

LAINE

HELP! IS ANYONE OUT THERE? HELP ME!

Laine turns and runs, shouting into the darkness, a frantic energy possessing them.

LAINE (CONT'D)
Somebody! Anybody at all!

Suddenly, a powerful, unnatural FUST of wind rushes through the trees, a deafening ROAR that drowns out Laine's cries. Amidst the roaring wind, familiar snippets of the "River Talks" podcast voiceover ECHO from every direction.

AVON & LAINE (V.O.)
Nature walks so rivers could talk.
River Talks is now streaming!

AVON (V.O.)
Avon, we need to decide on a
streaming service...

LAINE
(Screaming over the wind)
Shut up!

The wind stops abruptly the moment Laine stops running and screaming. An eerie silence falls again.

Laine stares at the leaf, the "River Talks" logo now faintly etched into its surface in dew.

AVON (V.O.)
We can't get any good 'content'
with this audio. Use the mic.

Laine stands defeated, staring at another leaf that just landed nearby. They warily pick it up, holding it like a mic.

LAINE
No more content Laine. I'll kill ya
dead. I'll find wherever your voice
of yours is coming from and I'll-

AVON (V.O.)
And here we have a classic "Laine
Defense Mechanism." When things get
real, we get violent. We push. We
break. We cancel our Netflix
subscription-

LAINE
(Sobbing)
I didn't want to break! I just
wanted to breathe!

AVON (V.O.)

You can't breathe if you're always
holding your breath, waiting for
the other shoe to drop. Or in this
case... the other leaf.

Laine falls to their knees. Clawing at the dirt, their hands
are now sickly yellow and brown. Their skin itches.

LAINE

I sent flowers to your funeral!

AVON (V.O.)

Flowers die in three days, Laine.
Then they join the landfill.
Leaves? Leaves turn into the earth.
They stay. You never liked staying.

LAINE

Because staying put just means
waitin' on the end! I up and left
so I wouldn't have to sit here and
watch you leave me behind!

AVON (V.O.)

But you're still watching me. Every
time you close your eyes. Every
time your phone rings. You're just
listening to a dead air and calling
it peace.

Laine stands, face contorted. They grab a low-hanging branch
and shakes it violently. Leaves rain down like shrapnel.

LAINE

You want yourself a finale? You
want "content?" Here you go!

Laine stomps on the fallen leaves. CRUNCH. CRUNCH. CRUNCH.

LAINE (CONT'D)

"Welcome on back to River Talks!
Today's episode: How to stomp out
someone who won't let you move on!"

AVON (V.O.)

Careful!

LAINE

Am I a-slayin' or what?!

AVON

You're- crushing- it-

Laine kicks the piles of leaves, sweeping their legs back and forth, trying to clear a path of bare dirt.

LAINE

I hate these woods! I hate this
fool podcast! I hate that you done
left me with nothin' but a
voicemail I can't ever delete!

Laine delivers a final massive kick to the green-brown pile.

The leaves hover in the air. They hum like Avon's hums.

The leaves land to arrange themselves into a waveform, a visual representation of the human voice.

Laine stops. Their chest heaves.

AVON (V.O.)

(Distorted, low battery)

I just- wanted- you to- be heard...

One leaf displays a PAUSE button then... The waveform straightens into a flatline on a heart monitor.

LAINE

Heard. Don't you go doin' that now.
Don't you go all quiet on me.
That's my move, remember?

Laine drops to their knees, fumbling to piece the shriveled leaves into a pulse.

LAINE (CONT'D)

I wasn't ready to be "River Talks."
I just wanted us to be "Us." But
"Us" is done gone, and all I have
left is these foolish recordings of
a life we didn't get to finish.

Laine pieces the leaves into a regular heartbeat.

BADUM. BADUM. BADUM.

AVON (V.O.)

Wanna finish a finale episode?

LAINE

(A tearful laugh)
What title ya fixin'?

AVON (V.O.)

"Nature Walks So Current Comes and
Goes."

AVON (V.O.)
Now... tell our listeners where
we're walking to.

LAINE
We're walking... to the confluence.

AVON (V.O.)
Confused... Explain to our audience
what a "confluence" is.

LAINE
Where two streams meet up.

AVON & LAINE (V.O.)
Nature walks so rivers could talk.
River Talks is now streaming!

Laine looks down into the stream. They see the leaf that
settled at the shore in the first scene.

Laine picks up the leaf. They pull out their marker and
write: "Not now. Next time?"

AVON (V.O.)
Thanks for finally responding and
not ghosting me. Now look. Well,
you can't cause I'm an invisible
ghost~

Laine rolls their eyes, amusingly.

EXT. NATURE BRIDGE - MORNING

The woods no longer are nowhere. The sun rises, revealing
Laine by Avon's memorial. Laine is facing the stream, now
looking human again.

AVON (O.S.)
Please don't leave...

Avon steals away Laine's leaf from behind. They hold it like
a mic. Laine turns to finally see Avon's full face.

AVON (CONT'D)
...me.

Laine kisses Avon.

LAINE
Puns. Leave. Comes natural to you.

Laine releases the leaf into the stream where it floats away.

Avon fades away behind Laine.

INT. LAINE'S BEDROOM - MORNING - FLASHBACK

Laine finally picks up the phone. In their hand, the phone reveals Avon's text: "Thanks for being my voice."

MATCH CUT TO:

EXT. NATURE BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

We see Laine's empty hand.

Laine takes a deep breath and returns to the nature trail.

FADE OUT.

THE END